# Mortalium Animos

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The Promotion of True Religious Unity His Hottness, Pore Pius XI Reprinted from the N. C. W. C. News Sheet.

To Our Venerable Brethren, Patriarchs, Primates, Archbishops, Bishops and to all Ordinaries in Peace and Communion with the Apostolic See; Venerable Brethren, Greetings and Apostolic Benediction:

The will to strengthen and to diffuse for the common good of human society that brotherhood in which we are all closely united by the bonds of a common nature and origin has never perhaps so taken hold of men's minds as in our times. When nations do not fully enjoy the bless- ings of peace, and' old and new discords break forth into mutiny and conflict ; when, indeed, it is impossible to set- tle the numerous controversies that strike at the peace and prosperity of peoples without the harmonious action of those who govern states and rule and promote their in- terests, it is easily understood, and all the more so now that all accept the unity of mankind, how it is that, im- pelled by the desire for universal - brotherhood, many should be anxious that the various nations stand ever more closely together.

Some are seeking to we a thing not unlike this in matters that concern the ordinations of the New Law which Christ brought to us. Convinced that rarely, indeed, do men lack all sense of religion, they seem to draw from this reason to hope that without great difficulty it may come about that all peoples, no matter how dif- ferent their religions, will stand fraternally together in the profession of a few doctrines which will serve as a kind of common foundation for the spiritual life. There-

fore they are accustomed to call congresses, reunions and meetings which are attended by many persons and they invite there indiscriminately to decide the question, infidels of all kinds and Christians alike and even those who have miserably apostatized from Christ or who intransigeantly and tenaciously deny the Divinity of His person and mis- sion.

CATHOLICS CANNOT APPROVE

Certainly such undertakings as these cannot gain the approval of Catholics since they are founded upon the false teaching of those who say that since all religions equally unfold and signify, though not in the same way, that native, inborn feeling in us all through which we are borne toward God and humbly recognize His rule, there- fore all religions are more or less good and praiseworthy. The followers of this theory are deceived and mistaken and since they repudiate the true religion by attacking it in its very essence, they are in fact moving step by step to naturalism and atheism. Hence it clearly follows that he who gives assent to such theories and undertakings separates hmiself wholly from Divinely revealed religion.

When the question of promoting unity among Christians is under consideration many are easily deceived by the semblance of good. Is it not right, it is said repeatedly, indeed, does it not conform with the duty of all who call upon Christ's name to cease mutual recriminations and in ties of mutual charity join together? For who would dare to say that he loves Christ when he will not strive to his utmost to attain what Christ prayed for to His Father when He asked that His disciples might "be one?' And did not Christ wish His disciples to bear the sign and be distinguished by the characteristic of love towards one another: "By this shall all men know that you are My disciples, if you have love one for another ?"'? Would that all Christians were one, they add, in order that the evil of irreligion might be driven from us which now is spreading more widely every day and threatens to overturn the Gospel itself.

1John xvii, 21.

2John xiii, 35.

Directed By Non-CATHOLICS

These and like arguments are brought forward and amplified by those who call themselves Pan-Christians. They are no longer confined to small and scattered groups but, so to speak, they are growing by whole phalanxes and are uniting themselves in extensive organizations which although they themselves are of different faiths are directed for the most part by non-Catholics. The work itself is promoted with such zeal that it has already gained a great variety of followers and has even ensnared the minds of Catholics with the entrancing hope of attaining a union that would seem to meet the will of Holy Mother Church to whom nothing is more hallowed than the re- call and the return of her wandering children to her bosom. Yet beneath the coaxing words there is concealed an error so great that it would result in destroying totally the foundations of the Catholic Faith.

In the consciousness of Our Apostolic office not to let the flock of the Lord be led astray by error, We in- voke your zeal, Venerable Brethren, to ward off this evil; for We are convinced that by means of your writings and your words, the principles and reasons We shall expound will more quickly reach the people and they will come better to understand them so that they will know how to judge and how to conduct themselves in relation to the efforts made to coalesce in one body through some sort of a pact all who call themselves Christians.

CHURCH ESTABLISHED By CHRIST

God, the Maker of the universe, created us that we might know and serve Him; it follows that our Maker has full right that we serve Him. For the governance of mankind God could have prescribed only the one law of nature which He wrote upon the mind of man at his creation and thenceforward He could have ruled the steps of this law under His customary providence. Instead He preferred to give us the Commandments to prepare us,

and in the course of the centuries from the origin of man-

kind to the coming and teaching of Christ Jesus He

wished Himself to teach man the duties that rational beings owe their Creator.

"God, who, at sundry times and in divers manners, spoke in times past to the fathers by the prophets, last of all, in these days hath spoken to us by His Son."* From this it follows that the true religion cannot be other than that which is founded in the revealed word of God. This revelation, started at the beginning of time and continued in the Old Testament, Christ Jesus Himself perfected in the New. Now if God has spoken—and that He has in- deed spoken is historically certain—there is no one who does not see that it is man's duty to believe God abso- lutely in His revelations and to obey Him without quali- fication in His Commandments ; and precisely that we may rightly fulfil both duties for the glory of God and our own salvation, the Only Begotten Son of God founded His Church upon earth.

They who profess themselves Christians cannot, we think, but believe in Christ's establishment of one Church and one Church alone; but when one asks what that Church ought by the will of its Founder to be, then not all are in agreement. Indeed a great many deny, for ex- ample, that Christ's Church ought to be visible; at least in the sense that it should stand forth as one body of faithful united in one identical doctrine and under one head. On the contrary they understand by a visible church nothing but a society formed of various Christian com- munities even though these adhere to different doctrines and even to doctrines mutually contradictory.

Instead the Church which Christ Our Lord founded is a perfect society, external of its own nature and visible, which would pursue for all future time the task of saving mankind through the guidance of one head*; through be- ing taught by a living voice®; and through the dispensa- tion®; of the sacraments, those fountains of heavenly grace; wherefore, in His parables He likened His Church to a kingdom'; to a house*; to a sheepfold®; to a flock''.

'Hebr. i, 1 sq. 4Matt. xvi, 18 seq.; Lk. xxii, 32; John xxi, 15-17. 5Mark xvi, 15. 6John iii, 5; vi, 48-59; xx, 22 seq.; cf. Matt. xviii, 18, etc. 7Matt. xi, 33. SCf. Matt. xvi, 18. *John x, 16. 2°John xxi, 15-17.

Such a Church so marvelously constituted could not cease altogether and be extinguished when its Founder and the Apostles who first propagated it had died, because it had been commanded to lead to eternal salvation all men without distinction of time, or place: "Going, therefore, teach all nations.""* Would the Church lack power or efficacy for the perpetual fulfilment of this work when Christ Himself is perpetually present with it, as He solemnly promised: "Behold I am with you all days even to the consummation of the world' ?'* Necessarily, therefore, the Church of Christ ought not only to stand to- day and always, but still more it ought to remain the same as it was in the Apostolic ages, unless we should wish to ut- ter the absurdity that Christ Our Lord either had not been adequate to His purpose or had erred when He asserted that "the gates of hell shall not prevail against it.'

OpporTUNITY TO REMOVE FALSITY

And here there is presented the opportunity of setting forth and removing a falsity upon which it seems this whole question hinges and from which is drawn the origin of the multiple effort of these non-Catholics who are striving, as we have said, for the confederation of the Christian churches.

The authors of this plan are in the habit of quoting the words of Christ: "That they all may be one... . There shall be one fold and one shepherd,''* yet in the sense that these words express a desire and a prayer of Christ Jesus that has been thus far unanswered. They contend that the unity of Faith and government, which is the sign of the true and only Church of Christ has almost never existed up to this time and does not exist today; it can be desired and perhaps in the future it can be obtained through general good will but meanwhile it must be censidered a fiction. They say, moreover, that the Church by its very nature is divided into parts, that it consists of many churches or particular communities which are separated among themselves and, although they

Matt. xxviii, 19. 12Matt. xxviii, 20.

13Matt. xvi, 18. 14John xvii, 21; x, 16.

have certain points of doctrine in common, differ in others ; that each enjoys the same rights; that at most the Church was the one and only Church between the Apostolic era and the first Ecumenical Councils. Therefore, they add that the controversies and old differences of opinion, which up to our time have prevented the union of the Chrisitan name, should be completely put aside and with the remaining doctrines there ought to be formulated and proposed a common rule of faith in the profession of which all can know and feel themselves brothers ; and that only when united by some sort of universal covenant can the multitude of churches or communities oppose fruitfully and effectively the progress of unbelief. This, Venerable

3rethren, is the more general opinion.

There are, however, some among them who assume and grant that Protestantism, as they call it, has rejected inadvisedly certain articles of faith and certain external rites of worship which are fully acceptable and useful and which the Roman Church still preserves. But they add immediately that the Church has corrupted the early re- ligion by adding to it and by proposing for belief certain doctrines that are not only foreign to but are opposed to the Gospel, among which they bring forward chiefly that of the primacy of jurisdiction assigned to Peter and his successors of the Roman See. Among them are also a few, though a very few, who grant to the Roman Pontiff a primacy of honor or a certain jurisdiction and power which, however, they derive not from Divine right but in a cer- tain manner from the consent of the faithful; and others even add that they wish the Pope to preside over these multicolored conferences.

SEEK BAsIs OF EQUALITY

If, however, it is easy to find many non-Catholics preaching often of brotherly love in Christ Jesus, you will, indeed, find none to whose mind it would occur to submit themselves and obey the Vicar of Christ either as teacher or as ruler of the Church. Meanwhile, they af- firm that they wish very much to treat with the Roman Church, though upon the basis of equality of rights and as equals; if they could so treat, they do not doubt but

that an agreement might be entered into through which they would not be compelled to give up those opinions which are the cause why they have thus far wandered outside the one sheepfold of Christ.

On such conditions it is clear that the Apostolic See cannot in any way participate in their reunions and that Catholics cannot in any way adhere or grant aid to such efforts; if that would happen it would give authority to a false Christian religion completely foreign to the one Church of Christ. But could we suffer—which would be iniquitous—the truth and indeed the Divine revealed truth to be brought down to the level of bargains? For it is

the safeguarding of revealed truth now that is being con- sidered.

If Jesus Christ sent His Apostles throughout the whole world to imbue all nations with the evangelical faith and that they might not err in anything He desired that they be taught all truth by the Holy Ghost,'® could this doctrine of the Apostles disappear or even be darkened ina Church of which God Himself is the ruler and guard- ian? And if Our Redeemer openly said that His Gospel cared not only for the Apostolic period but also for all future generations could it be that the content of the Faith would become in the passing of time so obscure and un- certain as to permit today the acceptance of opposed opin- ions? If that were true one must likewise say that the coming of the Holy Ghost upon the Apostles and the end- less abiding in the Church of the Holy Ghost and even the preaching of Jesus Christ have for these many centuries

lost all efficacy and usefulness. But to affirm that, would be blasphemy.

Moreover, when the Only Begotten Son of God com- manded His legates to teach all nations, He then obliged all men to place faith in these things that had been an- nounced to them by "witnesses preordained of God,"® and He attached to His command the sanction, "he that be- lieveth and is baptized shall be saved: but he that be- lieveth not shall be condemned."*? Now this double com-

mandment of Christ which must necessarily be observed, to teach and to believe so as to attain eternal salvation can- not even be understood if the Church does not propose the

John xvi, 13. 16Acts xi, 41. 17Mark xvi, 16.

evangelical doctrine entire and clear, and if in the teaching of it it were not free from all danger of error.

Gop REVEALED TRUTH

How far are they from the truth who indeed think that a deposit of truth exists on earth but who think too that one must search for it with so much tiring labor and lengthy studies and disputes that hardly is the life of a man long enough to find it and enjoy it; as if the most kind God has spoken through the prophets and His Only Begotten Son that a few only and these already bowed down in years should learn the truth that He has "revealed and not that man might have a teaching of faith and morals through which he would be ruled throughout the whole course of his life.

It might appear that the Pan-Christians, engaged in trying to confederate the churches, are pursuing the noble idea of promoting charity among all Christians. Yet how can charity come from harm done the Faith? All remember how John, the very Apostle of charity, who in his gospel seems to have revealed the secrets of the Most Sacred Heart of Jesus and who inculcated always in the minds of his disciples the new commandment, "Love ye one another," had wholly forbidden them to have relations with those who did not profess entire and uncorrupted the doctrine of Christ: "If any men cometh to you and bring not this doctrine, receive him not into your house nor say to him, God speed you."?* Since charity is founded in whole and sincere faith, the disciples of Christ must be united by the bond of unity in faith and by it as the chief bond. How could a Christian society be considered whose members in matters of Faith could each retain his own way of thinking and judging, although it was contrary to the beliefs of others? Through what agreement could men of opposed opinions become one and the same society of the Faithful?

How, for example, can they who affirm that sacred tradition is a true source of Divine Revelation, and they

who deny it become members of one church? They who hold that an ecclesiastical authority formed of bishops, priests and ministers is Divinely constituted, and they who

18]T John x.

assert that little by little it has been introduced through conditions of time and events? They who adore Christ really present in the Most Holy Eucharist by that won- derful change of bread and wine called Transubstantiation and they who say that the Body of Christ is present there only through the sign and the virtue of the sacrament; they who hold that in the Eucharist there is a sacrifice and a sacrament, and they who say that it is only a remem- brance or commemoration of the suffering of Our Lord? They who believe it good and useful to pray to the saints reigning with Christ and above all to Mary the Virgin Mother of God and to venerate their images, and they who pretend that such a form of worship is wrong because it draws from the honor due Jesus Christ, "the one mediator of God and men."?®

DIFFERENCES PREVENT UNITY

In such great differences of opinions we do not know how a road may be paved to the unity of the Church save alone through one teaching authority, one sole law of belief and one sole faith among Christians. Moreover, we know how easy is the path to neglect of religion, to indifferentism and also to modernism which holds the very same error, to wit: dogmatic truth is not absolute but relative, it is

proportionate to the different needs of times and places

and to the various tendencies of the mind since it is not based upon an unchanging revelation but is to be accom- modated to the life of men.

In matters of Faith it is, moreover, not permissible to make a distinction between fundamental and so-called non- fundamental articles of Faith, as if the first ought to be held by all and the second are free for the Faithful to accept or not. The supernatural virtue of Faith has as its formal cause the authority of God the Revealer, who does not make such a division. Therefore, as many as are of Christ give, for example, to the dogma of the Immaculate Conception the same faith they give to the mystery of the august Trinity and they believe in the infallible teaching power of the Pope, in the sense, be it understood, deter- mined by the Vatican Ecumenical Council. Not because

19Cf. I Tim. ii, 5.

the Church has defined and sanctioned truths by solemn decree of the Church at different times, and even in times near to us are they, therefore, of unequal certainty and to be given unequal faith; for has not God revealed them all ?

The teaching authority of the Church which by Divine providence was established in the world in order that re- vealed truths might always be preserved untouched, and quickly and with certainty come to the minds of men, is daily exercised by the Roman Pontiff and the bishops in communion with him. Still it has the duty to proceed op- portunely in defining points of Faith with solemn rights and decrees, when it becomes the duty to declare them in order to resist more effectively the errors and assaults of heretics or to impress upon the minds of the Faithful clearer and more profound expositions of points of sacred doctrine. However, in this extraordinary use of the teach- ing authority nothing is invented nor is anything new add- ed to the sum of truths that are, at least implicitly, con- tained in the deposit of Divine Revelation that was en- trusted by God to the Church, but instead points of Faith are defined that could still seem obscure to some, or truths are established as matters of Faith that for the first time were entering controversy.

CATHOLICS FORBIDDEN PARTICIPATION

Therefore, Venerable Brethren, it is clear why the Apostolic See has never permitted its children to take part in these congresses of non-Catholics; because the unity of Christians cannot be otherwise obtained than by securing the return of the separated to the one true Church of Christ from which they once unhappily withdrew, to the one true Church of Christ, standing forth before all and which by the will of its Founder will remain forever the same as when He Himself established it for the sal- vation of all mankind. ~The mystical Spouse of Christ has remained unspotted in the course of the centuries nor can it ever be contaminated. St. Cyprian says: 'The Spouse of Christ cannot commit adultery; she is incorrupt and modest, she knows one house, she guards with chastity and modesty the sanctity of one room."*® The holy mar- tyr marveled, and with reason, how any one could think

20De Cath. Ecclesiae unitate, 6.

that "the unity which proceeds from the stability of God

and is bound together by the sacraments of heaven could be torn asunder in the Church or divorced by discordant wills." For since the mystical Body of Christ, that is to say, the Church is, like the physical body a unity,"* a compact thing, closely joined together,** it would be false and foolish to say that Christ's mystical Body could be composed of disjointed and separated members. Whoever, therefore, is not united with it is not a member of it nor does he communicate with its head who is Christ.** In the one Church of Christ no one is found there and no one perseveres in it unless he recognizes and accepts obediently the supreme authority of St. Peter and his legitimate successors. Did not the very ancestors of those who were confused by the errors of Photius and the Protestants obey the Roman bishop as the high shepherd of souls? Children did, alas, abandon their father's house but the house did not therefore fall in ruins, supported as it was by the

unceasing help of God. Let them return to the common father of all; he has forgotten the unjust wrongs inflicted against the Holy See and will receive them most lovingly. If, as they repeat, they desire to be united with Us and with Ours, why do they not hasten to return to the Church "the mother and mistress of all the followers of Christ' ??° Let them listen to Lactantius erying out: "It is only the Catholic Church that retains the true worship. It is the fountain of truth, it is the household of the Faith, it is the temple of God, so that if any one does not enter it or if any one departs from it, he is a stranger to the hope of life and salvation. No one should be deceived by continuous disputes. Life and salvation are in the balance; if they are not cared for carefully and diligently they will be lost and destroyed."** _ Let these separated children return to the Apostolic See established in this city which the Princes of the Apostles, Peter and Paul, consecrated with their blood, to this See, "the root and matrix of the Catholic Church,''?? not, indeed, with the idea or hope that "the Church of the liv- 21] bid. 221 Cor. xii, 12. 23Eph. iv, 16. 24C{. Eph. v, 30; i, 22. 24Conc. Lateran, IV, ¢.5. 26Divin. Instit. 4, 30, 11-12.

27S. Cypr. Ep. 48 ad Cornelium, 3.

ing God, the pillar and ground of truth''** will abandon the integrity of the Faith and bear their errors, but to subject themselves to its teaching authority and rule. Would that what has not been granted to Our predecessors would be granted to Us, to embrace with the heart of a father the children over whom We mourn in their separa- tion from Us by evil discord. May God Our Saviour, "who will have all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth,''*® hearken to our ardent prayer and vouchsafe to call back all the wanderers to the unity of the Church! In behalf of which lofty intention We in- voke, and We ask that you invoke, the intercession of the Blessed Virgin Mary, Mother of Divine Grace, Conqueror of all heresies and Help of Christians, that soon there may dawn that longed-for day when all men will hear the voice of her Divine Son "keeping the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace."*° You know well, Venerable Brethren, how much We want their return; and We desire too, that all Our children know it and not only they of the Catholic world but all who are separated from Us. If they who are separated from Us will ask in humble prayer the grace of God, there is no doubt but that they will recognize the one true Church of Jesus Christ and enter it united at last with Us in perfect charity. In expectation of it and as a sign of the favor of God and a witness of Our Father- ly benevolence to you, Venerable Brethren, and to your clergy and people We impart the Apostolic Blessing.

Given at St. Peter's the sixth of January, the Feast of the Epiphany of Our Lord Jesus Christ, in the year nineteen twenty-eight, the sixth of Our Pontificate.

Pius XI, Pope.

281 Tim. iii, 15. 29T Tim. ii, 4. 30Eph. iv, 3.

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